TICKET TO NEPAL



Politics exports talent to unexpected places. Take **Sandeep Rana**, the new Nepal MP who won on a Nepali Congress ticket in the elections there. He cut his teeth in Delhi's student politics, working with current BJP general secretary Sunil Bansal during his Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) days. Rana later joined the BJP's formidable campaign machine, and was even part of Amit Shah's core team after 2014 when he became party president. Party sources say Rana saw first-hand the BJP's obsession with booth committees, voter mapping and such before returning home in 2018. Nepal's politics may run on a different frequency, but if Kathmandu suddenly sees unusually frenetic party activity, the Delhi connection won't be hard to spot.

DRY SPELL TO STAY

With **Nitish Kumar** on the verge of stepping down, a familiar question is bubbling up in Bihar: will prohibition survive him? NDA voices have grown louder in recent weeks, openly pushing for a review of the liquor ban. But on March 7, Nitish confidant and transport minister **Shravan Kumar** delivered a warning—as long as the JD(U) was part of the government, no one need expect any tinkering with the CM's flagship policy. Bihar finds itself in a curious limbo: succession imminent, whispers of change louder than ever, but for now, dry conditions persist.



SPICY DOES IT



Andhra Pradesh IT minister **Nara Lokesh** doesn't forgive or forget easily. Some time ago, Karnataka minister **Priyank Kharge** called him a "scavenger" after Lokesh tried poaching entrepreneurs from Bengaluru. Payback came when Google announced a $15 billion (Rs 1.4 lakh crore) AI hub in Visakhapatnam in October 2025. As Kharge grumbled, Lokesh tweeted: "They say Andhra food is spicy. Seems some of our investments are too. Some neighbours are feeling the burn!" Now, he's got another opening with Karnataka's plan to ban social media for kids under 16. AP issued a similar notice in January, and Lokesh was quick to cry copycat.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Mishra, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava and Prasad Nichenametla

ECO WATCH

POWER LINES VS PLUMAGE
SAVING THE BUSTARD

By **Rohit Parihar**

Few conservation efforts carry such a staggering price tag as India's attempt to save the Great Indian Bustard (GIB). With barely 130-150 of the tall desert birds left in the wild, the Supreme Court's earlier direction was to underground power lines across large parts of Rajasthan and Gujarat, with costs pegged at Rs 20,000 crore. A December 2025 review order now limits it to 'revised priority areas' in the Thar desert, covering about 14,013 sq. km in Rajasthan and 740 sq. km in Gujarat. Within these zones, the most dangerous power lines—especially 33 kV ones—must be undergrounded or rerouted. Around 80 km of such lines in Rajasthan and 144 km in Gujarat are to be immediately shifted underground, with another 250 km to follow in two years. The expected cost, Rs 5,000 crore, is still substantial, but far more workable for governments and power companies trying to reconcile conservation with infrastructure growth.

For the bustard—an ancient sentinel of the Thar—power lines are only part of a larger survival puzzle. The bird's last stronghold around Desert National Park and the wider Jaisalmer landscape is under pressure from shrinking grasslands, feral dogs and the rapid spread of solar and wind projects. In recent months, the felling of khejri trees for large solar parks triggered protests by local communities and environmentalists. The backlash forced Rajasthan chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma to promise legislation banning the cutting of the revered desert tree.



SHOCKED The Great Indian Bustard

The lessons are clear: ecological planning done early costs far less than emergency rescues later. The fate of one of the world's heaviest flying birds now depends not just on breeding success in the desert, but on how carefully India plants the wires and roads of the future.